TOOLS AND CHECKLISTS · D3

Stage Checklists

Five one-page checklists for the nights that matter: Initiation, the second meeting, before and after Passing, before and after Raising, the first Lodge of Instruction.

For	Personal Mentors, with the Lodge Mentor, DC and Tyler
Issue	Issue 1a (Draft for Review), October 2026: the July 2026 text set on the Provincial template

Checklist 1 - The Initiation Night

For the Personal Mentor (with the Lodge Mentor, DC and Tyler). Customs vary between Lodges - adapt to your own.

In the days before	☐ Draft Festive Board speech provided well in advance, for him to adapt and make his own ☐ Dress, timing, venue, parking or lift arrangements all confirmed ☐ A quiet word about practicalities: comfortable trousers (one leg will be rolled up), reading glasses in his pocket if he needs them, cash for the alms collection and raffle ☐ Any adjustments confirmed discreetly - mobility, kneeling, faith requirements, the Volume of the Sacred Law appropriate to him (via the DC and Secretary) ☐ Contact him the day before, or on the morning: "We're thinking of you. Arrive early. You'll be guided at every step."
On arrival	☐ Meet him at the door - he should never stand alone in the anteroom ☐ Introduce him to the Tyler and the Junior Deacon, who will look after him during the ceremony ☐ Introduce him to the Worshipful Master and DC if opportunity allows ☐ Reassure: everyone in the room has done this; the ceremony is symbolic, safe and dignified
During the meeting	☐ Sit as close to the Initiate as custom allows once he is admitted; quiet explanation and reassurance as events unfold ☐ Ensure someone is with him at every point he is outside the Lodge room
The Festive Board	☐ Explain Masonic Fire and the order of toasts before the meal - never let him struggle in front of the room ☐ Ensure he is seated according to Lodge custom and never left among strangers ☐ Be ready to support his response to his toast - he has the draft speech; steady him beforehand
End of the evening	☐ Congratulate him warmly; make sure others do the same ☐ Confirm the next Lodge date and your first one-to-one meeting - book it now, don't leave it open ☐ Present or signpost the Initiate's Guide and any Lodge welcome material, without overloading him

PREPARE runs through everything on this page: there should never be any surprises. The small human details - the trousers, the glasses, the cash - are everything.

Checklist 2 - His Second Meeting

The neglected danger point: a new Brother is treated as the hero of his Initiation, then too easily forgotten. Not in Hertfordshire.

Before the meeting	☐ Contact him in the days before: confirm he is coming, answer any questions the first month has raised ☐ Confirm the summons has reached him and decode it together - what each item means, how to reply, dining arrangements ☐ Regalia and dress checked - gloves, apron arrangements per Lodge custom
On the night	☐ Meet him on arrival again - the anteroom is still an unfamiliar place ☐ Practise the salute and step quietly in a side room before the meeting if he wishes ☐ Ensure he has the words for any odes or hymns the Lodge uses ☐ Sit with him or ensure a briefed Brother does; explain business items as they happen (Risings, ballots, apologies) ☐ If the Lodge works a higher degree, ensure an experienced Brother retires with him and uses the time well
The Festive Board	☐ Seat him with company that will draw him in - do not let established groups close around him ☐ Introduce him to two or three members he has not yet properly met, by name and interest
Afterwards	☐ Walk out with him; confirm the next contact and the next date ☐ Note anything that seemed to puzzle or unsettle him - cover it at your next one-to-one

SUPPORT is the principle under test at the second meeting. Isolation is one of the earliest predictors of disengagement - our task is to dispel strangeness quickly, through warmth, explanation and genuine friendship.

Checklist 3 - Before and After his Passing

The Second Degree deserves better than to be treated as a corridor between the First and Third.

In the weeks before	☐ Test questions learned at his pace - rehearse together until he is comfortable, never rushed to fit the Lodge calendar ☐ Explain the tradition: he is tested on competence before advancement, and the questions are also a chance to discuss what the First Degree meant ☐ Explain timing, format and general structure of the ceremony - never ritual detail ☐ Reassure about answering in open Lodge: everyone finds it daunting; rehearsal is the antidote
On the day	☐ Contact him the day before or on the morning ☐ Meet him on arrival; re-introduce the Tyler, Inner Guard and Junior Deacon
Soon after	☐ Meet within days: "What did you make of it?" - let him talk first ☐ Explain why he was not hoodwinked this time: he was already a member, proved by his answers ☐ Discuss the themes of the Second Degree - knowledge, reason, the Liberal Arts and Sciences - and their everyday relevance ☐ Ensure he can give the Signs, Token and Word of a Fellow Craft according to the Lodge's working ☐ Present and review the Fellow Craft's Guide ☐ Encourage him to witness a Passing at another Lodge - offer to go with him ☐ Begin the test questions for his Raising, at his pace

Readiness, not convenience: if he is not ready to be passed, the right response is to wait - and to fill the time well. What he will remember of a rushed ceremony is not the ceremony; it is the anxiety.

Checklist 4 - Before and After his Raising

The most significant of the three degrees - and the gateway to the highest-risk period for losing a member.

In the weeks before	☐ Test questions rehearsed and comfortable ☐ Prepare him practically: timing, format, general structure - and advise him to arrive well rested and having eaten ☐ Prepare him honestly for the ceremony's weight: it is powerful, unlike what has come before, and entirely symbolic, safe and dignified
On the day	☐ Contact him the day before or on the morning ☐ Meet him on arrival; re-introduce those who will guide him on the night
Soon after	☐ Check in within days of the ceremony - the reflective conversation matters more here than after any other degree ☐ Discuss the central teaching of the Third Degree at his pace: mortality, integrity, the life well lived ☐ Ensure he can give the Grip and the Five Points of Fellowship according to the Lodge's working ☐ Cover visiting: how to sign in, Visitors' Toast etiquette, respect for other Lodges' workings ☐ Explain the structure of Grand Lodge and Provincial Grand Lodge and their principal Rulers ☐ Present and review the Master Mason's Guide
The months after	☐ This is the danger window - many losses occur after the Third Degree, when the visible journey seems complete. Show him the road ahead: LoI, visiting, Provincial and Light Blue events, areas of personal interest ☐ In due course, and at his pace: the Royal Arch as the completion of the journey - information, not recruitment; the decision and its timing are his alone ☐ Watch for any dip in enthusiasm now the ceremonies have finished - see the Warning Signs card

The Third Degree is not the summit; it is the point where the real journey begins. ENLIGHTEN carries the load from here.

Checklist 5 - His First Lodge of Instruction

The LoI is the backbone of Lodge culture - and the first visit can underwhelm if nobody manages expectations.

Before he goes	☐ Explain what LoI actually is: a relaxed rehearsal - officers in different seats, corrections, restarts, laughter. Unexpectedly ordinary, and that is its charm ☐ Check what the evening will hold: if there is little for an Entered Apprentice, tell him honestly - "come anyway and I'll introduce you to a few people" - or steer him to a better week ☐ Confirm time, place, dress (usually informal - check your LoI's custom) and any cost
On the night	☐ Go with him, or arrange a named Brother to meet him at the door ☐ Introduce him to the Preceptor and explain the Preceptor's role ☐ No pressure to take work - attendance with the option not to perform is explicitly fine ☐ Involve him in something small if he is willing: following the book, a walk-through part
Afterwards	☐ Ask what he made of it; normalise anything that surprised him ☐ Encourage a regular pattern of attendance without turning it into an obligation - if he misses a week, the only right response on his return is warmth ☐ Never let LoI absence be met with jokes or pointed remarks - that culture loses members

A new member's first experience of an acrimonious or unwelcoming LoI can affect his participation permanently. Make it fun - people attend, and remain, because they enjoy it.